

THE SWANKY RIFLE CLUB GUESTHOUSE AT AMHAT IN SULTANPUR DISTRICT (LEFT) MAKES FOR A STRIKING CONTRAST WITH THE DILAPIDATED OFFICE OF THE UTTAR PRADESH STATE RIFLE ASSOCIATION (BELOW)



give me a receipt," says Nagendra Singh, a licence holder in Lucknow. The fee ranges between Rs 300 and Rs 5,000 from district to district. And in Bundelkhand, where a firearm is a status symbol, people are ready to shell out any amount to obtain a licence. What is most shocking in this scandalous saga is that the money has not been spent for the purpose it was collected for. Of the state's 71 districts, only one has a shooting range. There are more than three lakh licensees in Uttar Pradesh, but none has been trained by the DRAS nor has anyone been provided cartridges at subsidised rates.

The DRAS should have been affiliated to the State Rifle Association which in turn is affiliated to the National Rifle Association of India (NRAI). The NRAI promotes shooting all over the country through the state associations which function through the DRAS. But in Uttar Pradesh, the State Rifle Association is almost defunct. "Despite these DRAS, chaired by the district magistrates, having crores of rupees in their accounts, we have not been given a penny so far," says Syed Shariq Ali, general secretary of the



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SYED SHARIQ ALI, *General Secretary, Uttar Pradesh State Rifle Association*



**“I paid Rs 2,000 as Rifle Club fee, but the clerk in the DM's office refused to give me a receipt.”**

NAGENDRA SINGH, *Arms Licence Holder*

Uttar Pradesh State Rifle Association.

Most of the DRAS have not even deposited their affiliation fee for more than 10 years, a sum of Rs 1,000 a year. "Agra defaults by Rs 30,700, Allahabad Rs 8,700, Azamgarh Rs 34,000, Deoria Rs 36,000 and Farrukhabad Rs 9,800. In some places like Lucknow, the DRAS organise shooting events, but at a very cosmetic level only to show some expenditure," says Shariq. "Last year, the Lucknow DRA organised an event at the Lucknow Mahotsava, but instead of providing subsidised cartridges, the organisers charged more money from the participants," says a spokesperson of the state association. Ironically, the Lucknow Municipal Corporation is building a firing range near the Amausi airport without even taking the association in the loop. Questions are being raised if the corporation has the expertise and funds to maintain a firing range and organise events.

The misappropriation of Rifle Association funds and the shortage of funds with the State Rifle Association have triggered off an exodus of talented shooters from the state. Nearly a dozen players, including Mohammed Asab who won the double trap gold medal in the International Junior Shooting Competition in Germany in 2008, have sought no objection certificates from the state rifle association. Another gold medalist at the National Games and son of a truck driver, Farooq Ali, has received no financial help from the state either. "The officers of the state are bungling up the funds of the rifle association and the players are suffering," says Rajpal Singh, who has opened a private shooting range in Braut in Baghpat district to train young talents.

In view of the mounting menace of terrorism, naxalism and armed crimes, the DRAS should focus more on training people in handling weapons. But except for collecting the donation, they are doing nothing as a result of which most of the licensees do not know how to use their weapons. For them, using their weapons may turn into playing with fire in the face of a callous and corrupt administration. ■